Impetigo

Recognize contagious sores, get treatment advice, and limit spread

ABOUT THIS TOPIC

Impetigo is a contagious bacterial skin infection. It can start as sores or blisters and leave golden or honey-colored crusts. A health professional should assess suspected impetigo and advise whether topical or oral treatment is needed.

Everyday care and treatment

- Keep sores clean and avoid picking crusts. Wash hands after touching the area and keep fingernails short.
- Do not share towels, clothing, bedding, or personal items. Wash used towels and bedding regularly.
- Use prescribed treatment for the full advised course. Do not use leftover antibiotics or another person's medicine.
- Follow local school, work, and contact guidance until treatment has reduced the risk of spread.

WHEN TO GET HELP

Contact a clinician if sores are spreading, painful, near the eyes, or not improving with treatment. Seek prompt advice for a baby, a person with reduced immunity, fever, or rapidly worsening redness or swelling.

Sources for further reading

NHS - Impetigo - https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/impetigo/

Reviewed for this educational handout: October 2026. Recommendations can change and depend on local guidance, age, pregnancy, other health conditions, and medicines. This handout is not a diagnosis or prescription.